

Managing Cultural Tensions in a Franco-Indian IT Team

Recommendations for Effective Cross-Cultural Collaboration

Arihant JAIN Rajamanikam GANESAN Muhammad Danish JAVED
Hemanth Kumar KOKUTAM Poorna Sai Kishore MARISSETTI

Cross-Border Management – Professor Sylvie TOURNIER
AIS-SE Gr1 – Team 3

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Roadmap

Speaker	Topics
1. Arihant	Context, Co-Create Rules & Rebuilding Trust
2. Rajamanikam	Fix the “Yes” Problem
3. Danish	Break the Silence in Meetings
4. Hemanth	Dual Communication & Safe Channels
5. Kishore	Deadlines & Sprint Rituals

Context: 7 Cultural Dimension Mismatches

Root causes of team friction identified in our analysis:

- Direct vs. Indirect Communication
- Task vs. Relationship Orientation
- Mono- vs. Polychronic Time
- Egalitarian vs. Status (Hierarchy)
- Independent vs. Interdependent
- High vs. Low Context
- Compound: The MIS Cycle

Core Philosophy

No personal failures - only cultural defaults. Every friction has a structural remedy.

R1: Co-Create Team Operating Rules

Step 1: Acknowledge Differences (Trompenaars' "Recognize")

"We work differently. Let us spend thirty minutes setting ground rules so we don't assume everyone thinks the same way."

Co-defined ground rules:

- **Meetings:** 5-minute tolerance for start times, regardless of rank
- **Debate:** Disagreement is active engagement, not disrespect
- **Definition of "Done":** Specific quality & documentation standards
- **Escalation:** Standardized channel, owner, and timeline

R2: Fix the “Yes” Problem with Structured Scope

Cultural Conflict:

- **Mismatch:** Indirect “yes” (“I hear you”) vs. Direct expectation (“I commit”)
- **Result:** Scope accepted before it is understood

Example: Product Scope Mismatch

Client wanted a secure comms channel; team delivered a social network due to unvoiced gaps.

Structured Scope Process:

- **Scope Alignment:** Indian team restates requirements in their own words
- **Active Inquiry:** Ask: “*What could go wrong?*” to normalize voicing risks
- **Sprint Demos:** Biweekly demos to surface gaps early

R3: Break the Silence in Meetings

Cultural Friction:

- **Mismatch:** Silence as deference (Status) vs. Silence as apathy (Egalitarian)
- **Result:** Critical technical input is withheld during group calls

Example: Silent Engineering Manager

Sat through call without speaking because meeting structure did not prompt his input.

Active Meeting Design:

- **Preparation:** Send agenda & discussion points **24 hours before**
- **Assigned Topics:** Assign sections to individuals prior to the call
- **Round-Robin:** Prompt members directly for input
- **Written Input:** Shared docs for remote written inputs

R4: Dual Communication (Verbal + Written)

Medium Mismatch:

- **Low-Context:** Trusts explicit written records
- **High-Context:** Relies on fluid verbal exchange

The 24-Hour Agreement Rule

*"I will send a recap after each meeting.
Silence after 24 hours means agreement."*

Dual Protocol:

- Use verbal meetings for alignment & discussion
- Document decisions, action items, owners, and deadlines immediately after
- **Flips the "Yes" Problem:** Replaces verbal assent with a traceable written record

R5: Safe Channels for Early Problem Reporting

Reporting Friction:

- **Relationship-Orientation:**
Reporting problems risks disrupting group harmony
- **Result:** Issues stay hidden until they become critical
- **Root cause:** Speaking up feels like breaking group loyalty

Safety Protocols:

- **Private Check-Ins:** Weekly 15-minute 1-on-1s (private, not group)
- **Open Questions:** *"What is harder than expected?"*
- **Zero Penalty:** Publicly thank early risk flags (without naming names)

Principle: Make the cost of silence higher than the cost of speaking up.

R6: Align on Deadlines with Sprint Rituals

Temporal Friction:

- **Mismatch:** Monochronic vs. Polychronic views of deadlines
- **Definitions:** Divergent standards of quality and “done”
- **Symptom:** Late deliverables with incomplete documentation

Sprint Mechanics:

- **Two-Week Sprints:** Clear, bite-sized deliverables
- **Demo-Based Reviews:** Show working output, do not describe it
- **Spillover Meetings:** Active correction when work is incomplete
- **Written Quality Standards:** *Done = reviewed + documented + tested*

R7: Rebuilding Trust (5 Concrete Actions)

Trust damaged by the MIS cycle is rebuilt through repeated, visible behaviour changes:

- ➊ **Address friction without blame** – Name the pattern: different, not wrong.
- ➋ **Build momentum with small wins** – Franco-Indian pairings on low-risk tasks.
- ➌ **Create informal space** – Monthly lunches & casual Friday video calls.
- ➍ **Lead by example** – Model style-switching in daily communication.
- ➎ **Review regularly** – Group retrospectives every 3 months to adjust.

Merci

We welcome your questions.

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